

Recognize it

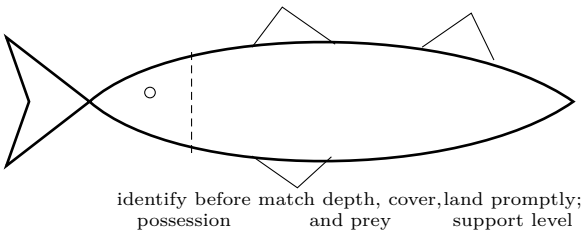
Golden fish with six to nine dark vertical bars and orange lower fins.

Body	Elongate panfish shape; two separate dorsal fins, first strongly spined.
Mouth/fins	Small toothed mouth; sharp gill-cover edge.
Confusion	Juvenile walleye is less golden, lacks orange lower fins, and has white tail tip.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Weeds, sand/gravel, flats beside depth, and winter basin edges.
Food and season
Insects, crayfish, and small fish; schools follow bottom prey and spawning routes.

A fish-shaped decision, not a lure list



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test deep weed edge and firm flats; use electronics to avoid fishing beneath suspended schools.
North	Test weed-to-sand transitions, narrows, and basin-adjacent flats.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Small jig.** Tip with worm or small plastic; maintain bottom contact with short lifts.
- 2. **Spread search.** Use a float or slow drift until a school is found, then tighten the area.
- 3. **Stop rule.** One fish may be chance; two at the same depth is a pattern. If the school leaves, search again.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Fold the first dorsal back carefully and avoid the sharp gill-cover edge.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Prefer thick mid-size perch; release unusually large females and stop when the meal is complete.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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